The BJP and Its Reimagining of the Northeast as the 'Eight Lakshmis'

The Northeast has been a prize that the BJP has long been focused on. Speaking at a gathering in Guwahati in February 2014, during his first prime-ministerial campaign, Narendra Modi used vivid Hindu religious imagery to showcase this ambition: 'Earlier they used to call it Seven Sisters. In my view, this is "Asht-Lakshmi", these eight states are "Asht-Lakshmi",' he said. 'And where does Lakshmi-ji reside? On the lotus [Kamal]. Lakshmi-ji's seat is the lotus. If you shower your blessings on the lotus once, and after Asht-Lakshmi takes its seat on it, we will achieve new heights in the development in all the eight states. We want to move forward with this aim.'[24] The term 'Asht-Lakshmi' refers to the eight-goddess manifestation of the Hindu goddess of wealth, who is traditionally depicted as sitting on a lotus,[25] which also serves as the BJP's election symbol. Once elected prime minister, Modi stressed again on this reimagining of the Northeast, also alluding this time to Vastu-shastra, the traditional Hindu art of architecture, and the importance it places on the East in construction design. As he put it, while flagging off the first train from Meghalaya to Guwahati in 2014:[26]

There are those of us who believe in Vaastu though I must confess that I do not know much about it. But if I were to believe what the experts say then the North East corner of the house should be well kept. It should be clean and its sanctity should be maintained at all times. If this is done the house will forever prosper. Well, I cannot verify these claims but what I do know is that if we are able to take care of North East India, the 'Ishan' corner of our homeland, then the entire India will prosper…. It is my firm belief that these 8 North Eastern states, our Ashta Lakshmi (eight goddesses of wealth), have the potential of bringing in prosperity for the entire nation … By connecting the North East, this Asht Lakshmi of India, by rail, we intend to make this region the most prosperous in India.